Ford Motor Company

**James P. Vondale, Director**
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

June 14, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S38 – 2002 Model Year Ford Thunderbird

This is to inform the agency that Ford will conduct a voluntary safety improvement recall program on the 2002 Model Year Ford Thunderbird as a result of a partial seat belt cut on the driver side, observed after a 35 mph frontal barrier NCAP test conducted by NHTSA. Throughout the impact, the driver side test dummy remained fully restrained by the seat belt and, we understand, preliminarily received a four star rating. Ford is not aware of any related incidents in vehicles in service and does not believe that the condition presents an unreasonable risk to motor vehicle safety. Testing conducted by Ford demonstrates that the seat belt actually was partially cut late in the impact while being unloaded. While occupant protection was not affected in the NCAP test, we recognize the agency's emphasis on seat belts and are, therefore, conducting this program to resolve this matter promptly.

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety improvement recall program involving 2002 Model Year Thunderbird vehicles, built from March 14, 2001 through April 24, 2002, to eliminate the potential for the driver side seat belt to contact the seat recliner as occurred in a 35 mph NCAP full-frontal barrier impact test conducted by the agency.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 16,500 vehicles (15,355 in the United States and Federalized Territories, 1,124 in Canada and 21 in other countries).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – None.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will be instructed to install an insert behind the driver side seat lower trim panel.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 – Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
02S38 5d/pcw/tab

ATTACHMENT

# 49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
# 02S38 – 2002 MODEL YEAR FORD THUNDERBIRD

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall program that it is voluntarily initiating.

## 573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

All 2002 Model Year Ford Thunderbird vehicles built from March 14, 2001 through April 24, 2002 at the Wixom Assembly Plant are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this program to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

## 573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 15,355 Ford Thunderbird vehicles in the United States and Federalized Territories.

## 573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Condition

All of the involved vehicles will receive the insert for the driver side seat lower trim panel.

## 573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Reason for the Action

In a 35 mph NCAP full-frontal barrier impact test the lap portion of the driver side seat belt webbing cracked the plastic driver side seat lower trim panel and contacted the seat recliner mechanism. Subsequent tests by Ford disclosed that as the belt unloaded at the end of the test, it pulled across the edge of the recliner resulting in a partial cut in the belt. During this NCAP test, the belt fully restrained the dummy and provided excellent occupant protection. Preliminary information is that the driver side dummy achieved a four-star rating. The partial cut of the belt did not reduce occupant protection in the NCAP test.

There have been no occurrences of the condition reported by vehicle owners and there are no reported accidents or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

On March 26, 2002 an NCAP test was conducted on a 2002 Model Year Ford Thunderbird at the MGA test facility in Milwaukee, Wisconsin. While the driver side dummy received a four star rating (preliminary) during the crash event, the lap belt loading for the driver side seat caused the outboard lower trim panel to crack, allowing the seat belt webbing to contact the seat recliner mechanism. During the unloading of the seat belt, the edge of the recliner mechanism caused a partial cut in the lap portion of the webbing.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Dealers will be instructed to install an insert behind the driver side seat lower trim panel.

There will be no charge to owners for this service.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford plans to make a public statement concerning the subject matter of this program. Dealer Notification letters will be sent out on June 14, 2002 and customer Notification letters will be sent out the week of June 17, 2002. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S38 to this program.